into the more formal doctrine known as 'Xi Jinping Thought on Chinese Diplomacy in the New Era'. His chief lieutenant for foreign affairs, Yang Jiechi, has announced that studying Xi Jinping Thought on diplomacy is an important political task for all those who engage in the conduct of foreign policy, beginning with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. [14] It has, therefore, become the go-to guide for the Foreign Ministry in the pursuit of all diplomacy, including diplomatic negotiation.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry only represents the proverbial tip of the iceberg in negotiations. Two other players are the armed forces and the intelligence set-up. The Chinese are militarily prudent; they will not fight unless they are certain of overwhelming victory or believe they are cornered. The Chinese may use the People's Liberation Army (PLA) to posture during the negotiations, to display capability and, in rare cases, to enter into a state of 'quasi war', where the PLA is deployed but in a way that is below the conflict threshold. So long as a settlement through negotiation is desirable and possible, the PLA is regarded as a tool to achieve a political objective without a conflict. [15] The Chinese Ministry of State Security (MSS), which is responsible for external intelligence collection, is the second instrument that China, like other states, uses in the negotiation process. The MSS increasingly employs modern methods, especially digital and cyber methods, to collect information about the other party's negotiating strategy and tactics, which could be helpful to China's negotiators.

This is where the similarities with the democracies stop in terms of the players. Since the Communist Party of China is the paramount authority in China, all diplomacy is managed by the Party (*dangyuan waijiao*). The absolute convergence of the Party and State in China allows the Chinese to deploy a formidable array of other actors to influence the course of negotiations, if needed. Some of these institutions are low-key or not well-